sensitive documents from the abandoned Brigade HQ. Once in Bomdila, Rawat briefed Lieutenant Colonels Bhupinder Singh and Gurdial Singh. All ideas and talk of counter-attacking the Chinese was to be abandoned. Instead, Rawat asked the two colonels to pull out of Bomdila and fall back to Rupa where 1 Sikh LI and 6/8 GR would be waiting for them. The brigade major clearly underlined the fact that these were the orders issued by the brigade commander, Brigadier Gurbax Singh.

The whereabouts of Gurbax Singh on the afternoon and night of 18 November are a mystery. Even more surprising is the claim made to the authors of the official history which records that the commander returned to Bomdila at 9 p.m. after having withdrawn to Rupa only at 4.30 p.m. Darshan Khullar explains: 'It so happened that Brigadier Gurbax had missed 3 JAK rifles because the latter were coming up a short-cut and not following the road. He halted at Tenga valley, got in touch with the Corps Headquarters and allegedly received instructions to head for the foothills. I say "allegedly" because early the next morning Major Nahar Singh, a signals officer from Corps headquarters, arrived with instructions from General Kaul to hold Rupa, about 14 kilometres south of Bomdila (Rupa's importance lay in that it was located at the tri-junction of tracks from Bomdila and Tenga and Rupa valleys; it dominated the tracks that went directly to Chaku via Pirila, and to Padung-Shergaon and onwards to Morshing-Kalaktang-Bhairabkunda). But where were the troops to hold these defences and, more pertinently, where was the time? Would the Chinese allow us the breather?'

By 3 a.m. on 19 November, the few remaining troops in Bomdila had begun to pull out. The Chinese promptly started shelling the withdrawing troops, even opening up with captured 4.2-inch mortars that had been abandoned by the Indians. Amazingly, All India Radio had already announced the fall of Bomdila the previous evening to stunned listeners across the country.

At around 7.30 a.m. on the morning of 19 November, Brigadier Gurbax Singh was seen with the commanding officer of 1 Sikh LI, the adjutant of 3 JAK Rif and officers from 6/8 GR trying to work out a plan for the defence of Tenga, Rupa and Chaku. 3 JAK Rif was to occupy a defensive position on a feature immediately north of the road to Tenga (the commanding officer, Lieutenant Colonel Gurdial Singh, along with his IO was already reconnoitring the ground on his own) while 6/8 GR would dig in just above